The four of us progressed through primary school together, barefoot until the age of 13. The younger boys never wore shoes at school, even in winter, and I was far from happy when the teachers forced me to wear shoes in my final year. I had been appointed head boy, and the head boy had to wear shoes.

The head boy also had to make a speech, standing in front of the school and welcoming everyone at the start of term. It was a Monday morning, as I recall, and the memory of that nightmare experience still makes me shiver. I was overwhelmed by nerves, and literally could not say more than a few words. It was horrendous.

In truth, I was much more at ease outdoors, playing sport, competing, getting into scrapes.

One afternoon all the Standard 5 pupils were swimming in the school pool and we were having a great time when an older boy called Allan arrived and told us to get out of the pool. It wasn't the first time this guy had given us a hard time, and I told him he was wrong and that we were allowed to be there.

'I said get out of the pool,' he repeated.

We had been throwing skidding catches at each other in the pool and, in a moment of madness, I took the wet tennis ball and hurled it at Allan, hitting him on the back, creating a red mark.

He turned round, instantly furious. We had one option. Run.

After scrambling to the entrance to the pool, we were soon sprinting along the narrow dirt path that led back to the sanctuary of the main school, but the older boys were too fast and soon caught up with us. We seemed set for a serious beating but, out of nowhere, Stof produced an amazing hand-off – I really couldn't believe my eyes – and I managed an inside-out sidestep and, somehow, we both got back to safety.

Allan was not going to let the matter rest there, and at the end of the day we saw him waiting for us outside the school gates. Unfortunately for him, in this particular week Stof and I were being collected by my elder